PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 4

Changing key

Music can travel to a new key and come home again: a **modulation**. The signpost is a new sharp, flat or natural that keeps coming back, and a cadence that lands in the new key.

THE SECRET

A new sharp or flat that keeps coming back, then a cadence: you are in a new key.

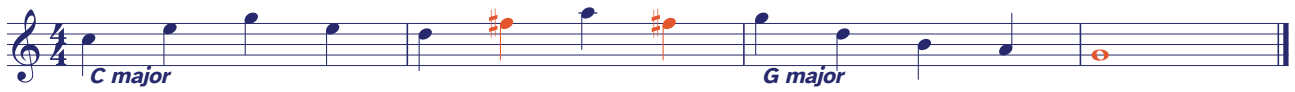


A trip away, and home again

The nearest keys

A piece in C major usually visits the keys next door on the circle of fifths (p. 102): only one note changes.
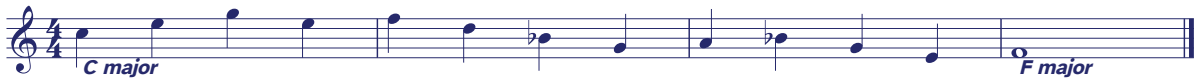
FROM C MAJOR TO	THE SIGNPOST	WHY IT IS CLOSE
G major	F♯ appears	the key a 5th up (one more sharp)
F major	B♭ appears	the key a 4th up (one more flat)
A minor	G♯ appears	the relative minor (same key signature)



Bar 1 in C major; F♯ twice in bar 2, then the phrase lands on G: now G major.

EXAMPLE 1

Where does the key change?



?

1. **Find the accidental.**
2. **Which major key** has one flat, B♭?
3. **Where** does the phrase land?

B♭ in bar 2 and again in bar 3, landing on F: **F major**.

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EXAMPLE 2

Which nearby key?

In G major, a C♯ keeps appearing ?

1. **G major** has one sharp, F♯.
2. **C♯ is one more sharp.**
3. **Which key** has F♯ and C♯?

D major, the key a 5th up: one more sharp.

EXAMPLE 3

A new key, or just passing?

One F♯ in a bar of C major, then F♮ everywhere after ?

1. **Does the F♯ come back?**
2. **Is there a cadence** in G?
3. **So**, a new key?

No: one passing F♯ is a decoration. A modulation **keeps** its new note and lands with a cadence.

GAME
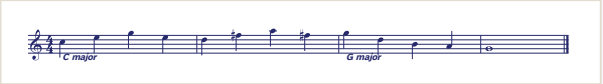
Where to next?

1. C major + F♯
2. C major + B♭
3. G major + C♯
4. F major + E♭

Which nearby key has the music moved to?

Answer: 1 G major · 2 F major · 3 D major · 4 B♭ major.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Hear the pull.

Play the four bars twice: once with F♮ in bar 2, once with F♯. With the F♯, the G at the end sounds like a new home.

THINK OF IT A modulation is a holiday: new scenery for a while, but the piece usually comes home at the end.

TRAP

- × Taking one passing accidental as a new key: it must keep coming back.
- × Missing the way home: most pieces end in the key they began in, so watch for the old note returning.

SEE ALSO

The circle of fifths p. 102 · Cadences p. 136

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Keys